

Mitigating Deepfake Harm in Online Communities: Insights from the BTS ARMY Fandom

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Abstract

Deepfake technology poses significant risks to online safety, particularly through non-consensual intimate media (NCIM), which disproportionately impacts marginalized groups. While current responses focus on technological detection or legal frameworks, there is limited understanding of how online communities address deepfake harm. This study investigates BTS ARMY, a global fandom centered on the South Korean music group BTS, as a case study to explore community-driven strategies for mitigating deepfake harm. Through a longitudinal ethnographic study of Twitter/X, we identify three key approaches: educational threads, reporting systems, and public condemnation. These efforts illustrate both the potential and limitations of grassroots action in combating NCIM. Findings highlight gaps in social media platform design and regulation, including ineffective reporting workflows and insufficient legal protections. This work provides preliminary recommendations for HCI, policymakers, and platform designers to enhance safety, amplify community efforts, and address deepfake harm through interdisciplinary solutions.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → Collaborative and social computing; Empirical studies in HCI; Social media; • **Security and privacy** → Social aspects of security and privacy.

Keywords

Deepfakes, Online Community, Online Safety, Fandom

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1 Introduction and Background

The rise of deepfake technology since its inception on Reddit's r/deepfakes in 2017 has introduced unprecedented challenges to online safety, privacy, and authenticity [8]. By 2023, deepfake content

increased by 550% compared to 2019, reflecting the rapid accessibility and popularity of AI technologies [27]. Modern deepfakes leverage advanced generative adversarial networks (GANs) to produce hyper-realistic videos in under 25 minutes, with no financial cost [27]. The rapid adoption of generative AI tools such as ChatGPT and DALL-E has further democratized access to these technologies, amplifying both their potential and their ethical challenges. This exponential growth not only represents a technical achievement but also raises critical societal concerns regarding trust, disinformation, and safety in digital environments.

Deepfake harm disproportionately affects women, with 96 - 98% of all deepfake videos online classified as non-consensual intimate media (NCIM) [1, 27]. Alarming, 99% of NCIM targets women, primarily female celebrities such as K-pop idols [27]. Beyond the devastating personal consequences for individuals, these violations extend to their broader communities. For celebrities, this includes their global fandoms, who encounter NCIM content and experience secondary harm. This includes emotions such as anger and self-conscious emotions such as shame in fans [29]. Furthermore, NCIM creators often exploit monetized platforms like FanTopia and MrDeepFakes to financially benefit from these violations, revealing the economic structures that perpetuate such harms [22].

While technical solutions such as deepfake detection models exist—with some achieving 92.7% accuracy in identifying manipulated content—these systems remain underutilized in everyday online platforms [10]. HCI researchers have emphasized the importance of designing accessible, user-centered tools that empower individuals to recognize and mitigate harm [7]. However, the gap between technological advancements and practical deployment leaves online communities vulnerable to the cascading effects of disinformation and privacy violations. Educational interventions and legislative frameworks are also in their infancy, highlighting the need for multi-faceted approaches that integrate technical, social, and policy dimensions.

This paper examines the BTS ARMY fandom, a global community of fans supporting the South Korean music group BTS, to explore how online communities develop safety practices against deepfake violence. ARMY¹ presents an exceptional case study for several reasons. Spanning millions of members across diverse cultural and geographic contexts, the fandom is largely female-presenting, reflecting the demographic most affected by NCIM deepfakes [12]. Moreover, the fandom is known for its strong emphasis on social mobilization and activism [20, 25]. Notable examples include fundraising for disaster relief, combating online hate through the

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¹Grammatically, the use of ARMY is unorthodox in English. ARMY can be a collective noun or a singular noun depending on the context (e.g., “ARMY are a community.” or “I am an ARMY.” or “These ARMYs love BTS.”)

#StopAAPIHate movement, and political interventions such as disrupting a controversial U.S. political rally through coordinated action [16, 23, 30]. Moreover, ARMY’s collective values emphasize authenticity and human connection, qualities embodied by the band members themselves [14]. Deepfake content, which directly undermines these values, has prompted community members to engage in proactive safety measures.

Despite their significant potential, online communities’ safety practices remain underexplored in HCI. While prior research has focused on developing detection algorithms and exploring the ethical implications of AI technologies, fewer studies more recently have examined how communities collectively address harm [15, 26]. This study addresses this gap by asking: *How do online communities develop safety practices against non-consensual intimate deepfakes to mitigate harm?* By investigating the BTS ARMY fandom, we provide insights into the strategies that communities employ to combat deepfake harm and their implications for HCI design and policy.

This paper contributes to HCI by broadening the focus from technical detection models to the social and communal dimensions of harm mitigation by making visible what large-scale global communities are already implementing. From these behaviors, we offer actionable recommendations for designing accessible, user-centered tools that integrate seamlessly into community platforms. Furthermore, our findings inform regulatory frameworks by highlighting the lived experiences of vulnerable communities and the legislative gaps they navigate in the current digital landscape.

2 Methods

This paper builds on qualitative methodological approaches through an ongoing online ethnographic study of the BTS ARMY community (e.g., [2, 3, 18, 21, 24]). The study investigates how ARMY addresses deepfake-related harm, leveraging the advantages of participant observation and ethnographic fieldwork to obtain rich, thick descriptions of community activities [4, 9].

2.1 Data Collection

Ethnographic fieldwork for this study was conducted from 2020 to 2025. Ethnographic data includes: participant observation by both authors, screenshots, and memos and field notes. Data for this portion of the study were collected through ARMY’s public social media posts on Twitter/X, focusing on conversations around deepfake-related harm. Publicly available posts were collected as screenshots, with a focus on key terms such as “BTS,” “Bangtan,” “deepfake,” and “AI.” These were informed by the authors’ extensive participant observation (See Ringland *et al.* [25]).

Conversations analyzed span from 2017 to 2025, encompassing 123 screenshots in total, with additional ethnographic notes. These posts included discourse from both general community conversations and nine prominent events in which deepfake content became a topic of collective attention. These nine prominent events included two South Korean news incidents, a hashtag campaign, a parody video, two arguments with other K-pop fandoms, a BTS member dating rumor, a reporting account accidentally sending ARMYs to report a realistic fanart, and a BTS deepfake posted onto

TikTok. This longitudinal approach allowed the study to capture evolving community practices and responses.

2.2 Data Analysis

To analyze the collected data, the first author employed an iterative, inductive approach informed by grounded theory [4, 5]. The analysis included ethnographic memos and screenshots, which were coded and categorized through emergent phenomena. The process involved reflexive engagement to identify patterns, themes, and narratives related to safety practices and deepfake-related harm. Themes were iteratively refined to align with the community’s social contexts, interactions, and shared understandings [4]. The thematic findings were cross-referenced with relevant literature in HCI and media studies to contextualize ARMY’s practices within broader frameworks.

Additionally, the first author maintained reflexivity as a member-researcher, acknowledging their analytical role and incorporating evolving reflections on their positionality. This approach ensured that the analysis remained sensitive to the “social contexts, interactions, sharing viewpoints, and interpretive understanding” inherent in the ARMY’s fandom activities [4].

2.3 Positionality and Ethical Approach

Ethics and positionality played a central role in this research. In line with best practices for digital ethnography, the first author exclusively analyzed publicly available information on Twitter/X and omitted content that had been deleted by users. Any data included in this manuscript has been paraphrased to protect individual identities. Furthermore, this study was exempt from institutional ethics board approval due to its exclusive reliance on public data.

The first author holds a dual identity as both a member of the ARMY community and a researcher. Their engagement with the fandom precedes their academic study of it, and they openly discuss their research online through a public-facing podcast and social media accounts connected to their fan identity. Although the fan identity operates under a pseudonym, the first author frequently shares and openly discusses academic materials under their real name, ensuring transparency with community members. This positionality has been essential for building trust, particularly given ARMY’s history of hostile encounters with researchers and media outlets [25].

ARMY is a diverse, global community encompassing a variety of identities, languages, and nationalities. The first author’s positionality as an Asian American researcher based in the United States introduces linguistic and cultural limitations. While this study focuses on publicly available English-language conversations, the first author notes the existence of relevant discourse in other languages such as Korean, Portuguese, and Spanish, which they cannot professionally translate or analyze. These linguistic and cultural nuances represent critical dimensions of ARMY’s practices that future research should address.

2.4 Scope and Limitations

The findings presented in this paper reflect publicly available, English-language conversations among ARMY members on Twitter/X. While this approach captures a significant portion of the

community's safety practices, it is not exhaustive. The multilingual, transnational nature of ARMY introduces complexities that cannot be fully represented within the scope of this study.

3 Findings

This study investigates three primary types of online fandom community responses to deepfake technology: (1) educational social media threads, (2) reporting systems for deepfake content, and (3) public condemnation and warnings aimed at deterring deepfake creation and distribution.

3.1 Educating the Community

Education within ARMY Twitter (defined as the fandom's community on X.com) manifests primarily through educational threads. These threads consist of multiple posts (tweets) that share information about deepfakes, such as their definitions, creation processes, and methods of recognition. Educational threads draw on colloquial definitions or authoritative sources, including university websites, and often provide safe-for-work examples of deepfake content. ARMY Twitter has historically used educational threads for other advocacy topics such as boycotting, American and South Korean politics, and current issues as well as BTS-related topics such as song lyric analysis, BTS's career history, and music video filming locations. In the case of deepfakes, these threads directly respond to posted deepfakes through quote posts, contextualizing and correcting the content.

Educational content frequently addresses the "slippery slope" narrative: the idea that non-intimate deepfake content, such as humorous or creative videos, contributes to the acceleration of non-consensual intimate media (NCIM). For example, non-intimate deepfakes include humorous edits, where BTS members are face-swapped into parody-like videos, or creative imagined scenarios, where members are possibly portrayed as fantasy heroes or special agents. These non-intimate examples are linked to NCIM by highlighting how such content trains deepfake systems to become more accurate. As face-swap systems are refined, blinking and blending improve, making future NCIM increasingly seamless and indistinguishable from reality.

Educational thread creators often appeal to fandom-specific values, such as protecting BTS, alongside broader ethical concerns, including legal, environmental, and feminist perspectives. Deepfakes get described as "sick," "scary," "out of control," "weird," and "nasty" within all of these perspectives. Legal perspectives involve the sexual and nudity aspects of the deepfake videos, calling on especially the South Korean government to act given the current deepfake NCIM issues in the country. Meanwhile, environmental perspectives describe the absurd amount of water usage for cooling at data centers and carbon emissions to produce deepfakes. One of the specific feminist perspectives focuses on how Korean women are disproportionately affected by NCIM deepfakes with this argument coming to its apex in September 2024 with the Telegram Sex Crime Hashtag Campaign started by Korean feminists. ARMY became active participants in this campaign, translating the original campaign's infographics into different languages such as French and Italian to further spread the campaign across X. Out of 123 screenshots collected for this poster, only one featured a

positive connotation towards deepfakes with the original poster using a sexually-gratified emoji to describe a deepfake they found of BTS. Posts with a positive perspective of deepfakes are usually hidden from search algorithms through the use of alternative terms, emojis, or censoring keywords. The fandom's emphasis on BTS's authenticity adds a unique layer to these perspectives, connecting deepfake harm to the violation of a core value in ARMY's identity.

Through these threads, ARMY members engage in a form of peer-to-peer education. Newly educated members often mimic the content and phrasing of prior threads, demonstrating how knowledge is shared and reinforced within the community. This can be seen in the parroting of the idea that the more AI is used, the more accurate it becomes. This same idea and phrasing can be seen repeatedly through ARMY Twitter. Increased educational threads on South Korea's current political climate around deepfake crimes has seen the emergence of phrasing such as "especially right now in South Korea" as well. Although some ARMY members seek additional information through shared resources like news articles and research, this behavior typically depends on prompts from already-educated ARMYs. In addition to text-based education, ARMYs create graphics and annotated images to help others identify deepfakes, which are easily disseminated across social media platforms, extending beyond the original poster's social circle.

3.2 Mobilizing Against Harm

Reporting systems within ARMY aim to address non-consensual intimate media of BTS members, leveraging both public and private methods. Public report posts typically include censored screenshots of NCIM, links to the original deepfake post, and the username or ID of the original poster. These posts generate urgency by visually highlighting the harmful content, prompting fans to act quickly to report and remove it. The posts also feature keywords and short messages emphasizing that the longer NCIM stays up, the more harm is done to the BTS members, which contributes to feelings of urgency. Once a post is removed, ARMY members often confirm its removal through follow-up posts.

However, this system is not without conflict. Misidentifications, such as mistaking realistic fanart or video edits for deepfake content, create tension between ARMY's reporting and creative subcommunities. Fanartists and editors may face harassment, despite their intentions to produce original or transformative work. These disputes derail safety efforts, shifting focus toward internal conflicts rather than external threats.

Private reporting systems operate through direct messages, group chats, and external platforms like Discord. Direct messaging chains often involve a leader disseminating a template message and post link, encouraging members to forward the message to others. This decentralized approach democratizes the reporting process, enabling members to take initiative. Group chats, in contrast, emphasize accountability through features like emoji reactions, which confirm participation in reporting. Discord servers add further organization by consolidating efforts in structured spaces.

Despite their effectiveness, private reporting systems are fragile. Internal disputes, such as disagreements over reporting priorities or leadership accountability, often spill into public spaces, exposing private content. These internal disputes become public as members

create “expose threads” sharing messages from and usernames of group chat members. Often, these expose threads are selectively cropped, which can lead to misinterpretation or incorrect framing of private discussions. Expose threads should be a tool for accountability, but often when there are genuine issues with management of the reporting space or possible social misconduct committed by leadership, there is a mix of personal issues that undermine the importance of genuine issues. In a hypothetical example reflecting real-life expose threads, a group chat leader can have their homophobic messages shared in an expose thread while the thread creator shares a personal grievance with the leader saying they did not like a particular BTS song. This fragility highlights the challenge of maintaining privacy and cohesion within semi-public platforms like X.com, where content can easily become visible to malicious actors or external observers.

In recent years, ARMY’s reporting tactics have faced challenges due to changes in X.com’s reporting algorithms post-Elon Musk’s acquisition in late 2022 [28]. Previously effective mass-reporting systems, which relied on multiple reports to increase takedown likelihood, have become less reliable. This stagnation has prompted discussions about the limitations of current reporting tools and the need for privacy-conscious design interventions in HCI to support community efforts.

3.3 Regulating Content through Condemnation

ARMY members also use public condemnation to deter the creation and distribution of deepfake content. Publicly, this involves quote posting or replying to ARMYs who share deepfakes, demanding the removal of the content. These posts often emphasize the harm that deepfakes pose to BTS and the fandom, including their potential to spread false narratives or be weaponized by anti-fans. These posts also share educational threads created by other ARMYs in their post replies, showing overlap in the mitigation methods. Condemnation appeals to the fandom’s shared value of “authenticity,” which is central to BTS’s identity as artists who write and produce their own music and openly advocate for social causes. Deepfake content contradicts this value by presenting false, unauthentic depictions of the members. Condemnations emphasize this contradiction by using words such as “fake,” “false,” “wrong,” and “fooling.” These words connote and draw attention to a deepfake’s unauthenticity, prompting ARMYs who share deepfakes to delete the content as they learn how deepfakes contradict a central ARMY value.

ARMYs also condemn deepfake creators who justify their actions as humorous or sexually gratifying. Public condemnations aim to curtail this behavior by emphasizing the ethical and safety implications of deepfakes. Within the broader context of X.com, where ARMY posts often go viral and ARMY shows their social media prowess as multiple BTS X posts have become the most liked and shared posts on the platform, these condemnations also function as a way to control narratives and maintain intimacy within the fandom. Condemnations feature ethical appeals by describing how the original poster would feel if a BTS member saw the post and disrespect to BTS’s bodily autonomy.

The interactions on ARMY Twitter highlight the dual nature of public and private condemnation, where both operate to maintain community norms and protect the fandom’s values. These values

work to highlight the community’s understandings of consent and technological practices.

4 Discussion

This study examined ARMY’s responses to deepfake content involving BTS members, revealing the innovative yet challenging strategies employed by the fandom to mitigate harm. Through educational threads, reporting systems, and public condemnation, ARMY showcases how online communities can take collective action to safeguard their members and maintain their values. However, their efforts also expose significant limitations in current platform design, legal frameworks, and the broader societal response to deepfake technology. This section discusses these findings, highlights their implications for HCI and policy, and proposes directions for future research.

The responses of ARMY reflect a proactive and resourceful approach to addressing deepfake harm, particularly non-consensual intimate media (NCIM). These strategies highlight both the potential and limitations of community-driven efforts in mitigating harm.

4.1 Opportunities for HCI to Support Community-Driven Efforts

This study identifies several opportunities for HCI researchers and practitioners to design systems that better support online communities in combating deepfake harm:

- **Enhancing Reporting Systems:** Current reporting mechanisms, particularly on platforms like Twitter/X, lack the transparency and effectiveness needed to address harmful content. Features like private group reporting tools, visual feedback on reporting progress, and transparent moderation workflows can empower communities to act more effectively while building trust in platform governance.
- **Integrating Deepfake Detection Tools:** Social media platforms should incorporate deepfake detection technology directly into their user interfaces, enabling individuals to identify and flag manipulated content with ease. By embedding these tools into platforms, HCI can reduce reliance on external resources and improve community safety.
- **Designing for Peer Education:** ARMY’s success with educational threads demonstrates the potential for platforms to amplify community-driven knowledge sharing. Tools for creating and disseminating trusted educational content, such as templates, tagging mechanisms, and enhanced sharing features, could help communities scale their educational efforts.

4.2 Beyond Technology: Regulation and Public Awareness

While technology provides critical tools for harm mitigation, this study highlights the need for systemic changes in regulation and public awareness. Current legal frameworks are fragmented, forcing victims and companies to navigate inconsistent avenues for justice with especially female celebrities being victim blamed for becoming

NCIM victims compared to male or female non-celebrities [6]. To address this, comprehensive legislation is needed to:

- (1) **Criminalize NCIM Deepfake Creation and Distribution:** Establish clear consequences for creators and distributors of harmful content.
- (2) **Hold Platforms Accountable:** Require platforms to proactively detect and remove NCIM deepfakes while providing transparency in their moderation processes.
- (3) **Support Victims:** Develop legal mechanisms for victims to seek reparations and justice without undue burden.

Additionally, public awareness campaigns are essential to complement these efforts. Currently, studies find approximately 4.4% of participants could name the act of deepfake NCIM and only 9% of people are confident in identifying a deepfake [6, 19]. While ARMY demonstrates how grassroots educational initiatives can be effective, broader campaigns supported by governments, platforms, and NGOs could amplify these efforts and reach wider audiences by creating education programs centering digital literacy [29].

4.3 Reframing Deepfakes as an Online Safety Issue

Current conversations around deepfake regulation often frame the issue as either a feminist concern or a national security threat [11, 22]. While these perspectives are valid, this study emphasizes the need to reframe deepfakes as an online safety issue that disproportionately impacts marginalized identities (*i.e.*, Asian and female) [27]. By analyzing ARMY's strategies, this research highlights the unique vulnerabilities of fandom spaces, particularly those centered on Asian male celebrities, and the broader implications for other marginalized communities navigating online environments. This reframing allows for more inclusive and comprehensive solutions.

5 Conclusion and Future Directions

This study contributes to the growing body of research on deepfake technology and online safety by analyzing the responses of ARMY, a global fandom known for its organizational capacity and commitment to community values [17, 20]. ARMY's responses—educational threads, reporting systems, and public condemnation—demonstrate the potential of online communities to take collective action against deepfake harm. However, their efforts also reveal systemic barriers, including ineffective reporting tools, the lack of integrated detection technologies, and fragmented legal protections. These systemic barriers must be addressed along with overall development of analytical thinking to make communities less vulnerable to deepfake videos [13].

The findings from this study highlight key opportunities for future work:

- (1) **Cross-Community Comparisons:** Future research should investigate how other online communities, particularly those centered on female celebrities or marginalized groups, respond to deepfake harm. Comparative studies could reveal shared challenges and strategies across diverse contexts.
- (2) **Translating ARMY's Practices:** ARMY's safety practices provide a valuable framework for other online communities.

Research should explore how these strategies can be adapted to different contexts, identifying ways to channel fan energy into broader social or legislative change.

- (3) **Expanding Multilingual and Cultural Perspectives:** This study focuses primarily on English-language content, but future work should incorporate multilingual analyses, particularly in Korean, Portuguese, and Spanish, where deepfake-related discourse may differ significantly. Examining these conversations will provide a richer understanding of global fandom practices.
- (4) **Advancing Regulatory Frameworks:** Interdisciplinary research should inform comprehensive legal protections against NCIM deepfakes. Policymakers must develop consistent and enforceable legislation that supports victims while holding platforms and perpetrators accountable.
- (5) **Improving Platform Design:** HCI researchers can collaborate with platform designers to develop privacy-conscious tools that balance collaboration and user safety. Features like secure reporting workflows, community moderation tools, and built-in deepfake detection capabilities can empower communities to protect themselves more effectively.

In the future, more work needs to be done to understand the impacts of these practices within communities on the creation and distribution of deepfake NCIM. By integrating these directions into future research and practice, we can advance a more comprehensive understanding of deepfake harm and create safer, more equitable online spaces. This work highlights the urgency of interdisciplinary collaboration among HCI researchers, policymakers, and community advocates to address deepfake harm as a multifaceted online safety issue.

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